

Word family: **seem / seemed / seeming / seemingly**

Base word: seem

Past tense: seemed

Past participle: seemed

Related forms: seeming, seemingly

Part of speech: verb (動詞) / adjective (相關形式) / adverb (相關形式)

Your sentence:

> “Then, as soon as they put the headphones on, everything **seemed to fade** into the background.”

Meaning in this passage

Here, **seem** expresses an **appearance or impression**, rather than stating something as an absolute fact.

Meaning: To appear to be happening or to give the impression that something is happening.

繁體中文: **根據當時的感覺或觀察，看起來／感覺上似乎正在發生某事，但說話者沒有把它當作完全確定的客觀事實**

中文翻譯:

> “Then, as soon as they put the headphones on, everything seemed to fade into the background.”

「然後，他們一戴上耳機，周圍的一切**似乎便漸漸淡到背景中、不再那麼引人注意**。」

seem to fade = 感覺上似乎逐漸變得不明顯／退居背景

1. **seem + adjective (狀態／特質) — 看起來；似乎呈現某種狀態**

Meaning: To give the impression of having a particular quality or condition.

Practice 1

> “She **seems tired** today.”

「她今天**看起來似乎很疲倦**。」

Practice 2

> “The office **seemed unusually quiet**.”

「辦公室**似乎比平常安靜很多**。」

seem + adjective = 根據外在跡象或個人感受, 看起來具有某種狀態或特質

2. **seem to + verb (動作／情況) — 似乎正在／似乎會.....**

This is the pattern in your original sentence.

Meaning: To appear, from the available evidence or impression, to do or experience something.

Practice 3 — Original

> “Everything **seemed to fade** into the background.”

「周圍的一切**似乎都逐漸淡到背景中**。」

Practice 4

> “The headphones **seem to reduce** most of the background noise.”

「這副耳機**似乎能減少大部分背景噪音**。」

Practice 5

> “He **seemed to understand** the problem immediately.”

「他**似乎立即明白了問題**。」

seem to + verb = 從觀察或感覺來判斷, 某個動作或情況似乎正在／曾經／可能發生

3. **seem to be + noun/adjective (身分／狀態) — 似乎是; 看來處於.....**

This is grammatically part of **seem to + verb**, but it is extremely common and worth learning as a pattern rather than a new lexical meaning.

Practice 6

> “This **seems to be** the best solution.”

「這個**看來似乎是**最好的解決方法。」

Practice 7

> “The system **seems to be** working normally again.”

「系統**看來**似乎已再次正常運作。」

seem to be = 根據目前跡象判斷, 某人／某事看來是或處於某種狀態

4. **it seems (that) + clause** (整個情況的判斷) — 看來; 似乎.....

Meaning: Used to introduce a conclusion or impression based on what you know or observe.

Practice 8

> “**It seems that** the problem has been fixed.”

「**看來**問題已經解決了。」

Practice 9

> “**It seems** nobody noticed the mistake.”

「**似乎**沒有人注意到這個錯誤。」

it seems (that)... = 根據目前資料、跡象或觀察, 說話者判斷某件事可能屬實

The **that** is often omitted in conversation:

> “It seems **that** he’s busy.”

> “It seems he’s busy.”

Both are natural.

5. **seem like + noun / clause** (整體印象／類似情況) — 看起來像; 感覺像

Meaning: To give the impression of being similar to something or of a particular situation being true.

Practice 10

> “It **seems like** a good idea.”

「這**看起來像是個不錯的主意**。」

Practice 11

> “It **seems like** everyone is working from home today.”

「今天**感覺好像大家都在家工作**。」

seem like = 從整體印象來看, 感覺像某種事物或情況

6. **seem as if / as though + clause** (彷彿某種情況) — 看起來好像; 彷彿

Meaning: To give the impression that a particular situation is true.

Practice 12

> “It **seemed as if** the noise had disappeared completely.”

「感覺**彷彿噪音已經完全消失了**。」

Practice 13

> “She **seemed as though** she had not slept all night.”

「她看起來**好像整晚都沒有睡過**。」

seem as if/as though = 根據外在跡象或感受, 彷彿某種情況真的存在或發生

This is close to **seem like**, but **as if / as though** normally introduces a fuller imagined situation.

7. **seem + noun** (身分／角色) — 看來是; 似乎是某種人／事物

This construction exists, although **seem to be + noun** is often more natural.

Practice 14

> “He **seems a reliable person**.”

「他**看起來是個可靠的人**。」

Practice 15

> “It **seemed a strange decision** at the time.”

「當時看來, 那**似乎是一個奇怪的決定**。」

seem + noun = 給人的印象是某種人物、事物或類型

In everyday English, you will often hear:

> “He **seems to be** a reliable person.”

8. **can't seem to + verb (想做但總是做不到／找不到原因) — 好像怎樣也無法.....**

This is a very common conversational pattern.

Meaning: Used when someone repeatedly fails to do something or cannot understand why something is not happening.

Practice 16

> “I **can't seem to find** my keys.”

「我**好像怎樣也找不到**我的鑰匙。」

Practice 17

> “She **can't seem to concentrate** in the noisy office.”

「她在嘈吵的辦公室裡**好像怎樣也無法集中精神**。」

can't seem to = 嘗試後仍然做不到某事, 帶有「不知道為甚麼就是不行」的語氣

This is not a completely new dictionary meaning of **seem**, but it is common enough that learners should know it separately.

9. **would seem / it would seem (較謹慎地作出判斷) — 看來似乎; 照目前情況看**

Meaning: A cautious or somewhat formal way of saying that the available evidence suggests something.

Practice 18

> “It **would seem** that demand is falling.”

「按照目前的跡象，**看來需求似乎正在下降**。」

Practice 19

> “The two problems **would seem to be** connected.”

「從目前情況看，這兩個問題**似乎存在關聯**。」

would seem = 以較保留、謹慎的語氣表示現有證據似乎支持某個判斷

Compared with:

> “They are connected.”

這是一個直接陳述。

> “They would seem to be connected.”

這表示：

「目前看來如此，但我不把它說成百分之百確定。」

10. **so it seems / it seems so** (根據目前情況確實如此) — 看來是這樣; 似乎如此

Practice 20

> “Are they closing the café?”

> **“So it seems.”**

「他們要把咖啡店關掉嗎？」

「看來是這樣。」

Practice 21

> “Is the problem getting worse?”

> **“It seems so.”**

「問題是不是愈來愈嚴重？」

「**看來似乎是。**」

so it seems / it seems so = 根據目前掌握的情況, 某個說法看來是正確的

11. **seeming + noun (表面看來的狀態) — 表面上的; 看似的**

Here, **seeming** is an adjective.

Meaning: Appearing to be true or real, especially when the reality may be different.

Practice 22

> “Her **seeming confidence** disappeared when the interview began.”

「她原本**表面上看似自信的狀態**在面試開始後便消失了。」

Practice 23

> “There is a **seeming contradiction** between the two statements.”

「這兩個說法之間存在一個**表面看來的矛盾**。」

seeming = 從表面看來具有某種性質, 但實際情況未必如此的

This form is considerably less common than **seemingly** or **apparent** in everyday speech.

12. **seemingly = apparently / judging by appearances (表面看來) — 看似; 似乎; 表面上**

Meaning: According to appearances, although the actual situation may be different or uncertain.

Practice 24

> “A **seemingly** simple problem took hours to solve.”

「一個**表面看似簡單的問題**竟花了幾個小時才解決。」

Practice 25

> “The two events were **seemingly** unrelated.”

「這兩件事**表面上看似沒有關聯**。」

seemingly = 從表面或現有跡象來看似乎如此，但實際情況可能不同

13. **seemingly = apparently true from available evidence (根據目前所見似乎如此) — 看來;顯然似乎**

Sometimes **seemingly** does not strongly suggest that the appearance is false. It can simply signal that this is the conclusion suggested by available information.

Practice 26

> “The company has **seemingly** solved the technical problem.”

「從目前情況看，公司**似乎已經解決了技術問題**。」

Practice 27

> “She was **seemingly** unaware of the change.”

「從她的表現看，她**似乎並不知道這項改變**。」

seemingly = 根據目前能觀察到的跡象判斷，情況似乎如此

I would **not** treat #12 and #13 as fully separate lexical meanings. They are two contextual shades of the same core idea: **appearance rather than certainty**.

The core idea of **seem**

Unlike a word such as **train**, **seem** does **not** have a large number of unrelated lexical meanings.

Almost all its common uses come from one core semantic idea:

> **Something gives the appearance or impression of being true, but the speaker is not presenting it as completely certain fact.**

The variety comes mainly from its **grammar patterns**:

* seem + adjective

* seem to + verb

* seem to be

- * it seems that...
- * seem like...
- * seem as if...
- * can't seem to...
- * would seem...

So we should ****not artificially split these into eight unrelated dictionary meanings****.

Important distinction: **seem vs be**

**be**

states something directly as fact.

> “She ****is**** tired.”

「她****很累****。」

**seem**

describes an impression or judgment.

> “She ****seems**** tired.”

「她****看起來似乎很累****。」

With ****seem****, the speaker leaves open the possibility that the impression could be wrong.

Important distinction: **seem vs look**

**look**

often emphasizes ****visual evidence****

> “You ****look**** tired.”

「你****看起來**很累**。」

**seem**

can be based on:

- * appearance
- * behaviour
- * information
- * circumstances
- * general impression

> “You **seem** tired.”

「你**似乎**很累。」

Perhaps your voice, behaviour, or lack of concentration gave that impression—not necessarily your physical appearance.

So **seem** is broader.

Important distinction: **seem vs feel**

This connects nicely with the earlier word **feel**.

seem

= something appears to be true based on evidence or impression

> “The room **seems** quiet.”

「這個房間**似乎**很安靜。」

feel

= the person experiences a more subjective overall impression

> “The room **feels** quiet.”

「這個房間**給人的感覺**很安靜。」

The difference can be subtle:

* **seem** → 判斷／表象

* **feel** → 主觀體驗／感受

Important distinction: **seem vs appear**

They overlap very strongly.

seem

Common and neutral in everyday English.

> “He seems worried.”

appear

Can sound slightly more formal and may emphasize outward evidence.

> “He appears worried.”

Both:

「他似乎很擔心。」

In formal reports, **appear** may be preferred:

> “The damage appears to be minor.”

「損壞看來似乎不嚴重。」

Important distinction: **seemingly vs apparently**

They overlap strongly.

seemingly

Often emphasizes **how something looks on the surface**.

> “a seemingly simple problem”

「一個表面看似簡單的問題」

apparently

Can mean either:

1. according to appearances; or
2. according to information you have heard

> “Apparently, the meeting has been cancelled.”

「據說／看來，會議已取消。」

So **apparently** has a reporting-information use that **seemingly** usually does not have in the same way.

Important grammar note: **seem** is normally a linking verb

We normally do **not** use **seem** in continuous forms.

Usually:

> “She **seems** tired.” 

not:

> “She **is seeming** tired.” 

Similarly:

> “It **seems** strange.” 

Because **seem** normally describes a state of appearance rather than an ongoing deliberate action.

Important grammar note: **seem** + adjective, not adverb

Because **seem** functions as a linking verb:

> “She seems **happy**.” 

not:

> “She seems **happily**.” 

The adjective describes the subject.

Compare:

> “She smiled **happily**.”

Here **happily** describes how she smiled, so an adverb is appropriate.

Family-extension note

The genuinely useful members of this family are fairly limited:

* **seem** = 似乎／看來

* **seeming** = 表面看來的; 看似的

* **seemingly** = 表面看似; 從表面／目前跡象看

Unlike **busy** → **busybody**, there is no large set of common everyday compounds derived from **seem** that would materially help our course.

So this is a good example of our updated Golden Manual rule:

> **Search broadly, but do not manufacture family members or extra meanings merely to make the entry longer.**

Master comparison

Form / pattern	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
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seem + adjective	根據外在跡象或個人判斷, 看起來具有某種狀態或特質
seem to + verb	從觀察或感覺判斷, 某個動作或情況似乎正在／曾經發生
seem to be	根據目前跡象判斷, 某人／某事看來是或處於某種狀態
it seems (that)...	根據目前資料或跡象, 判斷某件事情可能屬實
seem like...	從整體印象來看, 感覺像某種事物或情況
seem as if/as though...	根據跡象或感受, 彷彿某種情況真的存在或發生
can't seem to...	嘗試後仍做不到某事, 帶有「不知道為甚麼就是不行」的語氣
would seem	以較保留、謹慎的方式表示現有證據似乎支持某判斷
so it seems / it seems so	根據目前掌握的情況, 看來確實如此
seeming	從表面看來具有某種性質, 但實際情況未必如此的
seemingly	根據表面或目前跡象看似如此, 但並非完全確定

For your original sentence

> “Then, as soon as they put the headphones on, everything **seemed to fade** into the background.”

The exact meaning is:

seem to + verb = 根據當時的感覺或觀察, 某件事情看起來似乎正在發生, 但不是把它陳述為完全確定的客觀事實

So:

everything seemed to fade into the background

= **周圍的一切感覺上似乎逐漸變得不明顯、退居背景, 不再那麼吸引注意力**